

Letter from Carson Chang to General Albert C. Wedemeyer

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Lieutenant General Albert C. Wedemeyer
United States Presidential Envoy to China
United States Consulate General
Shanghai, China

Dear General Wedemeyer:

In the name of the Democratic Socialist Party as well as for myself I wish to extend to you my most heartfelt greetings of welcome. As personal representative of President Harry S. Truman, as well as an old friend of China, we are indeed grateful for your present appointment.

You have an important mission to perform, concerning not only the future security and peace of China, but also the future security and peace of the whole of the world, and I do hope that your mission will be a successful one.

In your position as presidential envoy on a fact-finding mission to China it might not perhaps be too presumptuous of myself to outline briefly the present situation seen in the light of the Democratic Socialist Party, a party that has fought so consistently for a democratic government in China.

You are undoubtedly well familiar with the Political Consultative Conference that met at the beginning of last year, and that although ending in failure still constitutes today the largest basis of agreement that was found between the Kuomintang and the Communist Party. The fact that the Manchurian question was left unsettled proved to be the breaking point of the agreements that were reached at the conference. At the time it was agreed that the national government send five divisions to Manchuria, while at the same time the Communists crossed northern China into Manchuria so that a clash became inevitable. The Generalissimo, supported in his view by the Sino-Soviet agreement, insisted upon the restoration of Manchuria by the central government, while Chou En-lai, saying that the Communists were Chinese too, insisted upon the same right.

At the end of March and the beginning of April the Democratic League stepped into the picture and proposed a democratic coalition government for Manchuria, an idea that the central government opposed as they maintained that Manchuria must be occupied by the nationalist armies first before any coalition could be established. In the ensuing months fighting increased in the north, until negotiations were reopened in June, with a most important agreement reached June 30th, that only broke down because of the Generalissimo's insistence in regard to Communist withdrawal from northern Kiangsu, Chengteh and Antung. At the time, Foreign

Minister Wang Shih-chieh told me that if he had not been a member of the Kuomintang he would have personally signed the agreements that were reached, showing well how close even the Kuomintang was to a final settlement of the question.

It was the breakdown of the agreements reached on June 30th of last year that finally convinced the Communists that the Kuomintang was not willing to settle the problems in question by peaceful means, but were more interested in fighting to the bitter end. While Chou En-lai, because of persuasion by the third parties, undertook another trip to Nanking, it had become obvious by this time that neither side was willing to trust the other sufficiently for negotiations to start in earnest again. And the refusal of the Communists to join the national assembly constituted the final breakdown of negotiations last year.

It is obvious that the present situation does not only involve the civil war between the Kuomintang and the Communist armies but it is closely interrelated with China's relationship to the Soviet Union, centering within the problem spot of Manchuria. Until March 1946 Soviet Russia indicated a sincere desire to hand over Manchuria, not to the Communists but to the nationalist armies. But after the transportation of most of the heavy industry from Manchuria into Russia it became clear that Russia was still interested in economic privileges in that region, and was only willing to cede this territory to the national government of China after such privileges had been granted. While the national government was hesitating on a decision in regard to this issue Soviet Russia opened the door for Communist armies to occupy this territory, and within one month enabled the Communists to take more than one hundred and fifty districts.

And so while Russia's attitude toward the central government in regard to Manchuria was rather friendly in the beginning, primarily because of the promise that the national government would only maintain a gendarmerie and no army in the Manchurian border region and would also refrain from building any heavy industry in that region, Russia's early withdrawal from Manchuria determined the fate of that region. And Manchuria today is as much of a problem as it was last year; it can clearly be seen that without a settlement of that question there can be no peace for China.

While the Manchurian problem constitutes the most obvious international point of friction, China internally is facing a grave crisis as well. The most hopeful sign in China's development toward a democratic government can well be seen in the constitution that was adopted at the end of last year. While the draft of the May 1937 constitution, a very undemocratic document indeed, stipulated that the national assembly meet only once every three years, provided a legislative yuan that had not the power to advise or control the executive yuan, and refused a self-government law to the provinces, the constitution that was adopted at the end of last year can be favorably compared with democratic constitutions adopted long ago by the Western countries.

It was largely because of the support of Chiang Kai-shek that the constitution now provides a responsible cabinet, a parliament, an examination yuan that is to be established on a non-partisan basis, a judicial yuan that is to function as a court rather than an executive organ of the government, and a control yuan that is to function as a committee of investigation, investigating illegal or incompetent actions on the part of the government, or members thereof. Whether this constitution will really serve as the foundation for a democratic government in China depends primarily upon the Kuomintang, the dominating majority party, and the interpretation it gives to this document. The theoretical foundation for a responsible democratic government has been laid; whether the Kuomintang is sincere in using this theoretical foundation for actual practical application, only the future can tell.

But aside from the adoption of the constitution there are few hopeful signs that China really finds herself on the path toward a democracy. While at the moment we find ourselves in a transitional stage from a one-party dictatorship to a constitutional government, there is actually little change of mind that one can detect on the part of the Kuomintang. Although the present government is representative of a semi-coalition government, many of the actions that the Kuomintang has undertaken during the last few months have not been performed in the spirit of equality or fair play. Let me only mention a few things.

First of all, personal freedom and individual rights have not been guaranteed to the citizens of China. The special secret police are still exercising their power in arresting citizens that are loosely suspected of Communist activities, or affiliation with other minority parties. While such arrests and such restrictions of personal freedom are always done in the name of peace and security, such undemocratic actions are primarily taken because of the privileged and powerful position of the Kuomintang Party.

Secondly, although the Kuomintang expenditures have now been separated from the national treasury, use is still being made of such national financial organs as the Farmers Bank to support the treasury of the party. Pressure is also placed upon industrial firms and enterprises in the various cities, as well as the people in the villages and districts to support the Kuomintang party financially. As the Kuomintang party represents to a great extent the national government, people as well as firms find it difficult to resist such pressure.

And thirdly, the Kuomintang's insistence upon their extra-legal privileges such as the appointment of government officials. With the creation of the State Council as the highest government organ, government appointees should be passed by that body, although so far the Kuomintang has not relinquished this right.

In the light of the coming election this privileged position on the part of the Kuomintang becomes a rather grave problem. A leading government official has expressed the thought that the Kuomintang is thinking of putting up more candidates for the coming election than there are vacancies. With the present control that the Kuomintang holds over the country, from the smallest village to the largest city, it becomes obvious that if the Kuomintang party does not restrain itself in putting up candidates it will be absolutely impossible for candidates representing the various minority parties to be elected to any office. And without restraint on the part of the Kuomintang in regard to the coming election a coalition government indeed becomes impossible. The question is not if the minority parties will win or lose, they undoubtedly will lose, but the question is whether a sufficiently large delegation representing the minority parties can be elected to office so that this minority can assure a faithful interpretation of the constitution.

Aside from this, minority party representation within the government also constitutes new blood that is so badly needed within the body of the government. According to my point of view, the people who are in power today are too "worn and torn" to constitute the real vitality that is so badly needed within our government. It is well known that old wine cannot be placed into new bottles, but the appointment of Yu Fei-peng as minister of food, and of Wang Shao-yung as vice-president of the control yuan constitutes the pouring of old wine into new bottles.

When the Democratic Socialist Party joined the government somewhat half-heartedly about three months ago, it did not hesitate because it was afraid of accepting such grave responsibility, but it hesitated because the party was too well familiar with the Kuomintang's ways of thinking and acting. Not only were we afraid of the bargaining methods that we feared would be and that were applied to the document covering 12 points in regard to the party's joining the government, but we also hesitated because although we were willing to join the government in spite of the continuation of the civil war, we expected a definite policy in regard to the conclusion of the civil

war and the reopening of negotiations.

Since the middle of last year the minister of national defense, and the chief of staff have expressed their confidence that the Communists can and will be defeated in three to six months. However, as was shown very clearly, such optimism was the result of emotional rather than logical or factual thinking. There are various reasons why the nationalist armies have not been able to conclude their task as effectively and quickly as was originally anticipated. For one, the army, including officers and enlisted personnel, are tired of war; their pay is so low that they are not able to support their families adequately, which constitutes a great temptation for the officers to spend most of their time trading on the black market rather than fighting the war; and also the neglect of proportion in regard to manpower and ammunition has been appalling.

The lack of cooperation and coordination within the hierarchy of the military organization has made it possible for officers on the fighting front to receive orders that were in actual contradiction to each other, aside from the fact that the various commands have lacked so far any sort of unifying power that enables petty personal differences to overshadow the urgency of concluding the civil war. The confused policy on the part of the government that sometimes stands for war and sometimes stands for peace has also greatly contributed to lower the morale of our armed forces.

Although with the recent serious military setback that the nationalist armies have suffered the government has become more aware of the seriousness of the situation, yet the general mobilization order that was issued last week cannot be interpreted in the light of Western military tactics; but actually the order is only meant to arouse the people toward the seriousness of the military situation, to arouse great patriotism which should be expressed in greater food and manpower contributions.

I personally cannot believe that the war will be finished in a short time, and because of this I have urged all along that political reforms must take place before military victories can be hoped for. Some time ago I proposed to the Generalissimo that China be divided into three separate areas: first, the northeast area and the Yellow River territory must be considered as the fighting area; secondly, the territory north of the Yangtze River should be considered as a half-military and half-civilian area; and thirdly, the territory south of the Yangtze River shall be considered as a strictly civilian area, with its economic resources to be used for the economic reconstruction of the country.

Good provincial governors must be appointed in that area devoted to the maintenance of peace and order; industry and commerce must be encouraged, and emphasis must be placed on such exportable goods such as wood oil, tea, bristles, and so forth. It seems to me that if such a plan could be developed, the people of China could find new strength and hope for their country, and in this way would find encouragement to conclude the civil war with greater vigor.

Before China can accept guidance and aid from any foreign country, she must first be able to put her own house in order. In regard to the democratization of the government China must show her sincerity in observing the new constitution. As long as the Kuomintang party derives most of its power from the strength of its privileged position rather than from real popular support, the party as well as the country will rapidly deteriorate. The Kuomintang party must be willing to share the position and the privileges of other parties, and its leaders as well as members must be willing to abide by the same laws that govern the other citizens in the Republic of China.

So far we hope and expect that Generalissimo Chiang Kai-shek will be willing to accept new and liberal leadership within the government. There is today in China a good deal of leadership material that so far has been frustrated if not completely intimidated; this potential leadership

must be brought to the forefront and be given the sort of responsibilities that it deserves. Civil rights, once and for all, must be given to the people; martial law must be revoked, and people suspected of unpatriotic activities must be tried by due process of law and not by the local garrisons.

Second, the military command must be improved and better coordinated. Civilian leadership, as is the case in the United States, must be included in the military council, and army policies and leadership must be placed above that of the Whampoa Military Academy. The third major reform must center around provincial government and administration. Since the Northern Expedition the Generalissimo has feared the military power of the provincial governors and so has insisted upon a complete centralization of power in the hands of the national government leaving little or no freedom to the provincial governors.

Since the beginning of the war against Japan this centralization of power has extended itself into the fields of finance and industry, leaving the provincial governments completely dependent upon the central government, even to a point where the provincial budget must first be approved by the national government. At present the national government through its various departments is able to dictate most anything to the provincial government, extending from the establishment of provincial gendarmeries, schools, and experimental stations, to the recruiting of men and the control of the local industry.

It is essential that the districts and provinces in the country have enough financial power to carry on their own administrative work, and it is also essential that the local Kuomintang and Youth Party headquarters no longer interfere in the running of the local, district or provincial governments and administrations. It would indeed be useless if the government would now succeed in establishing a democratic government while the people in the villages and small towns are still ruled by a one-party dictatorship, and it is essential that the provinces be given a chance to govern themselves as much as the country at large is in need of a broader democratic basis of participation.

And lastly, there must be certain economic reforms. Military expenditures must be kept within the national budget, and funds must be spent for their original purposes. There must be a clear demarcation between the field of finance and the issuing of bank notes; only after such a line of demarcation has been drawn can a currency reform be introduced that constitutes a stable medium of exchange.

With the foregoing broad program in regard to the democratization of the country, the Democratic Socialist Party joined the government a few months ago, and in so doing assisted the government in concluding its period of political tutelage, with the hope that a constitutional government would really come into effect by the end of this year. If the constitution should not be enforced in the spirit in which it was written, the party will have to reconsider its stand, as we firmly believe that China today is ready for a broader democratic foundation than exists at the moment.

But we also realize that China's condition at present is closely connected with America's position in the Pacific, realizing that if China is strong and united she could well serve as a stabilizing factor in the Far East and in the field of world politics. At present there are two schools of thought in regard to China's foreign policy: the first one is defended by the reactionary elements within the Kuomintang Party who believe that China not only has to fight the Communists but eventually will also have to fight against the Soviet Union. The men who defend this school of thought are exceedingly anxious to use the fear of the Soviet Union that is so prevalent in the United States today as a tool so as to be able to persuade America to aid wholeheartedly the Kuomintang armies in their fight against the Communists.

The counterpart to this school of thought is the Communists themselves, and it is not hard to imagine where their allegiance lies. But aside from these two extremist schools of thought there must be a third one: that China first of all must be able to put her house in order before she is capable of using adequately any foreign aid; and secondly, the school of thought advocates that China be neither pro-Soviet Russia nor pro-United States, but instead of being a future battleground for these two powers, China should try to become a common meeting ground on which these two nations can meet in harmony and peace.

If China could follow this third school of thought and democratize her own government and bring together harmoniously Russia and America, then China could take a worthy place in the family of nations. To enable China to follow this middle way, the following policy in regard to Manchuria should be adopted. While Manchuria must be turned back to the national government, the latter should agree to the fact that no heavy industry should be built along the Manchurian border region, and secondly the national government must see to it that the provincial government in Manchuria maintain a friendly attitude towards the Soviet Union.

On the basis of such a policy the United Nations Organization with the consent of the Soviet Union could then be asked to send a fact-finding mission into Manchuria so that an actual reconciliation could be found. If such a policy could be adopted in regard to Manchuria it would not only go a long way in aiding China in her conflicting relationship with the Communists and with the Soviet Union, but it would also go a long way in bringing the Soviet Union and the United States closer together.

In regard to possible American aid for China I believe that unless China is able to democratize her government she will not be able to use any such aid effectively. It will indeed be important for China to receive America's guidance and aid when and where democratic administrations have been established. At the moment America is in a good position to use a promise for guidance and aid as a tool to bring about a quicker democratization of the country, and the Chinese people are looking to America to use that tool as effectively as possible.

It is with admiration and with gratitude that we have so far received America's guidance and aid, and it is with great hope and anticipation that we are concerned with America's policy in China, hoping that it might be spent as wisely in the future as it has been spent in the past. Hoping that your mission will meet with every possible success, I remain

Yours sincerely,

Carson Chang
Chairman, Democratic Socialist Party